

Then—and this is the key point—after dinner, while everyone is still around the table, you’re going to pull out the receipt from your teen’s shopping trip, and proudly announce that they’ve just fed the entire family for under \$30—whereas the same meal as a takeaway would have cost you \$120 or more.

The genuine, heartfelt praise and applause from guests will leave a lasting impression on your teen’s brain—and you can guarantee they’ll remember this lesson for the rest of their lives.

Money Meal ‘shopping list’

- Photocopies of the recipes.
- \$30 in notes (or whatever budget you decide on).
- Teens will need to shop for their meal this week, so depending on how old they are, you may need to accompany them, or at least drive them.

If you’re doing this with tweens or younger kids, you can have some fun shopping:

- Play ‘where’s the milk?’ (Supermarkets always make you walk to the back of the store to get milk, in the hope you’ll be tempted to buy more as you go through the aisles.)
- Challenge them to find the cheapest product by comparing the unit price (per 100 grams)—but also take the opportunity to explain why sometimes you might pay more for some things, like free-range eggs.
- Point out that the most expensive things tend to be stacked at eye level, so people will spend more.
- When you get home, grab a tea towel and do a blind taste test of generic versus brand-name products. (Liz and I have done a blind taste test between artisanal pooped-out-of-a-civet-cat coffee beans and Aldi coffee beans—at a third of the price. Aldi won.)

Once your shopping is done, it’s time for your Money Meal—the Grandparents’ Dinner Party.